

08

Anti-Marshall Systems

8.a4, h3 move orders, and restrained centers that deny Black the ideal pawn sacrifice.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will avoid the Marshall for strategic reasons while accepting the different concessions of each anti-Marshall setup.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate candidates for the side to move, identify the opponent's strongest resource, and choose the resulting structure you can explain. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 043 | PAGE 4

Decode: 8.a4 restrains ...b5*Avoiding one system means accepting another; know what a4 weakens and attacks.*

LESSON 044 | PAGE 8

Play: 8.a4 restrains ...b5*Avoiding one system means accepting another; know what a4 weakens and attacks.*

LESSON 045 | PAGE 12

Decode: Early h3 move order*A move-order tool is successful only if you know the new position it creates.*

LESSON 046 | PAGE 16

Play: Early h3 move order*A move-order tool is successful only if you know the new position it creates.*

LESSON 047 | PAGE 20

Decode: Anti-Marshall d3 center*In anti-Marshall positions, the game returns to Spanish maneuvering; improve the worst piece.*

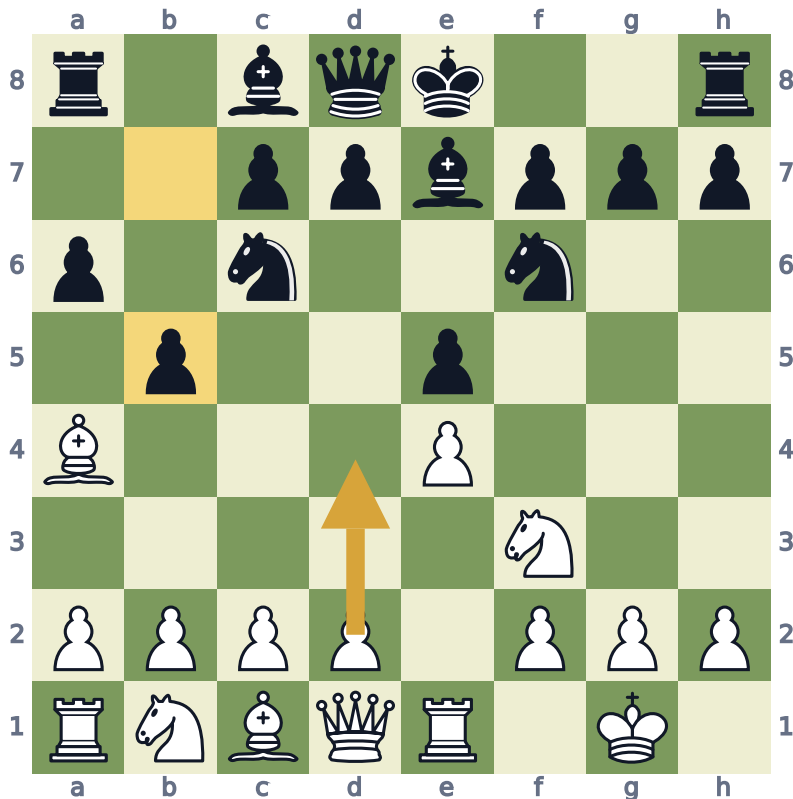
LESSON 048 | PAGE 24

Play: Anti-Marshall d3 center*In anti-Marshall positions, the game returns to Spanish maneuvering; improve the worst piece.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will avoid the Marshall for strategic reasons while accepting the different concessions of each anti-Marshall setup.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: 8.a4 restrains ...b5



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

a4 attacks the queenside chain and changes Black's ...d5 sacrifice because b5 can become loose.

DECISION RULE

Does a4 win a target now, or does it merely force Black into a different stable structure?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Black maintains development, protects the queenside, and switches toward central or kingside piece play.

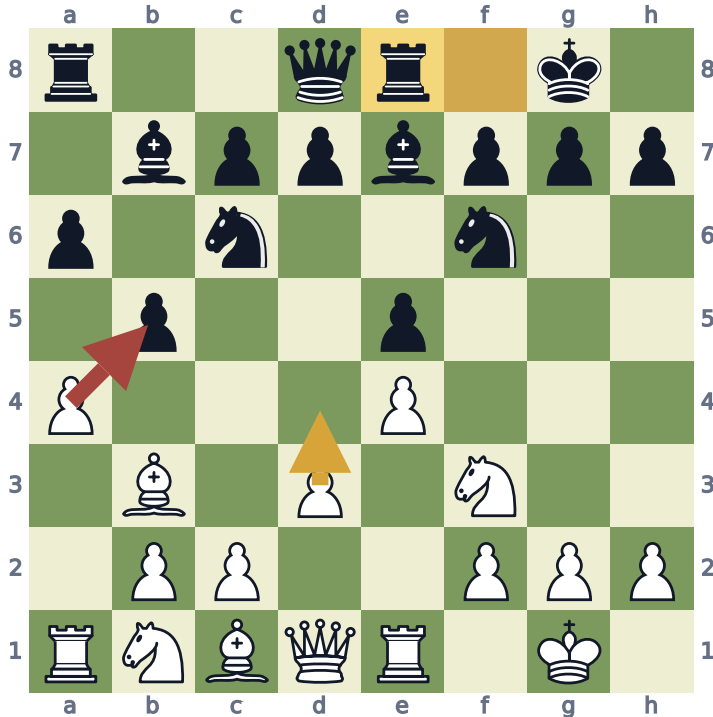
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White fixes a queenside target, keeps the center compact, and later chooses c3-d4.

MEMORY RULE | Avoiding one system means accepting another; know what a4 weakens and attacks.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

a4 attacks the queenside chain and changes Black's ...d5 sacrifice because b5 can become loose.

BLACK'S PLAN

Black maintains development, protects the queenside, and switches toward central or kingside piece play.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White fixes a queenside target, keeps the center compact, and later chooses c3-d4.

FAILURE MODE

Assuming the Marshall is avoided and relaxing about Black's central activity.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does a4 win a target now, or does it merely force Black into a different stable structure? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

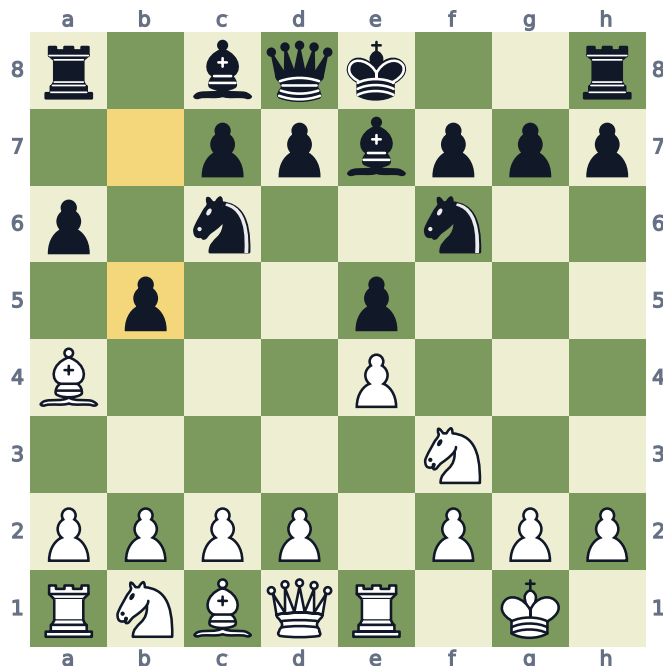
RULE | Avoiding one system means accepting another; know what a4 weakens and attacks.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. a4 Bb7 9. d3 Re8



- Ba4: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- b5: Black gains bishop tempo and queenside space while creating a possible pawn target.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

a4 attacks the queenside chain and changes Black's ...d5 sacrifice because b5 can become loose.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does a4 win a target now, or does it merely force Black into a different stable structure? White's resource is: White fixes a queenside target, keeps the center compact, and later chooses c3-d4. The line fails as a template when: Assuming the Marshall is avoided and relaxing about Black's central activity.

STORE THIS | Avoiding one system means accepting another; know what a4 weakens and attacks.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

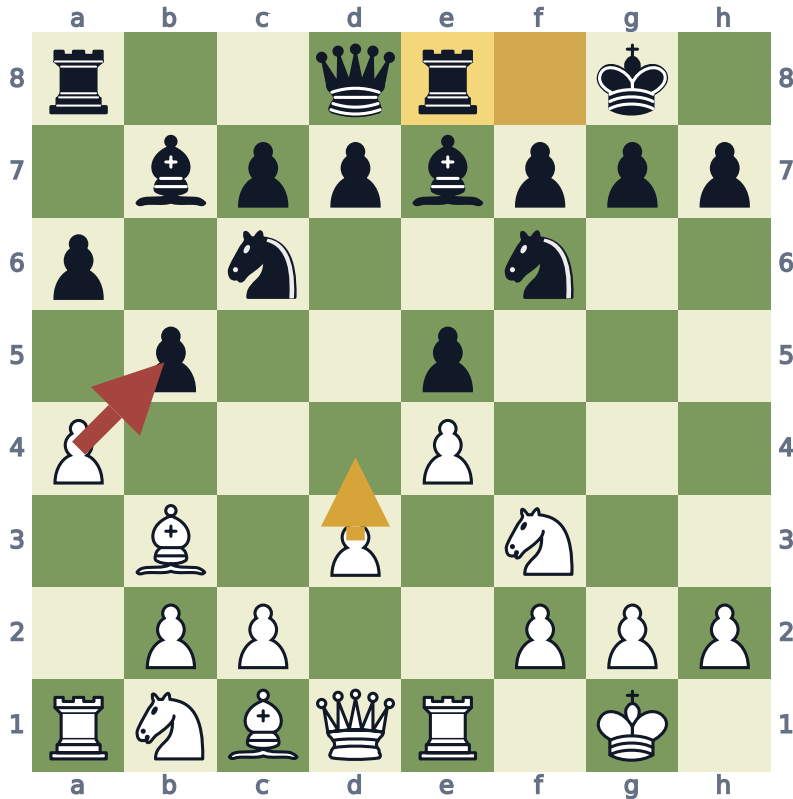
1. a4 attacks the queenside chain and changes Black's ...d5 sacrifice because b5 can become loose. 2. Black maintains development, protects the queenside, and switches toward central or kingside piece play. 3. White fixes a queenside target, keeps the center compact, and later chooses c3-d4. 4. Does a4 win a target now, or does it merely force Black into a different stable structure? 5. Assuming the Marshall is avoided and relaxing about Black's central activity.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: 8.a4 restrains ...b5



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

a4 attacks the queenside chain and changes Black's ...d5 sacrifice because b5 can become loose.

DECISION RULE

Does a4 win a target now, or does it merely force Black into a different stable structure?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Black maintains development, protects the queenside, and switches toward central or kingside piece play.

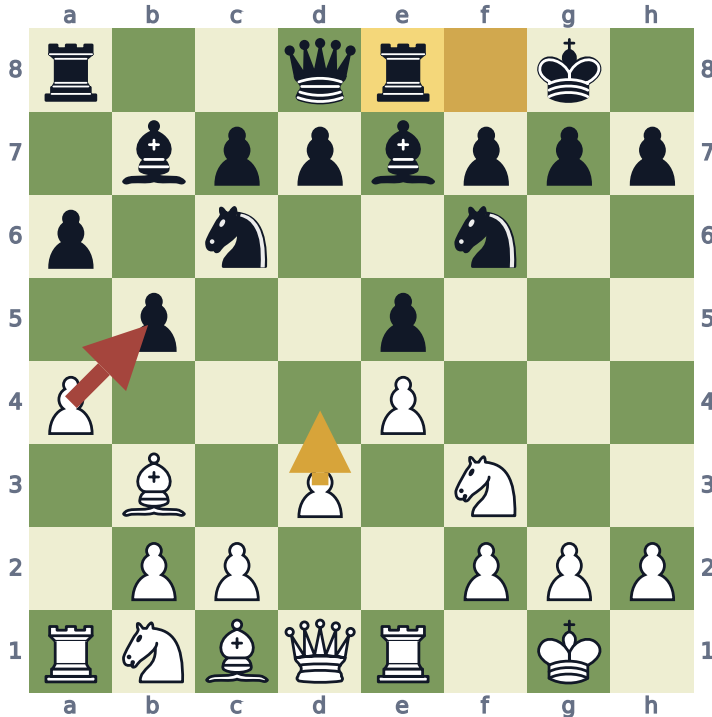
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White fixes a queenside target, keeps the center compact, and later chooses c3-d4.

MEMORY RULE | Avoiding one system means accepting another; know what a4 weakens and attacks.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

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FAILURE MODE

Assuming the Marshall is avoided and relaxing about Black's central activity.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Does a4 win a target now, or does it merely force Black into a different stable structure? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

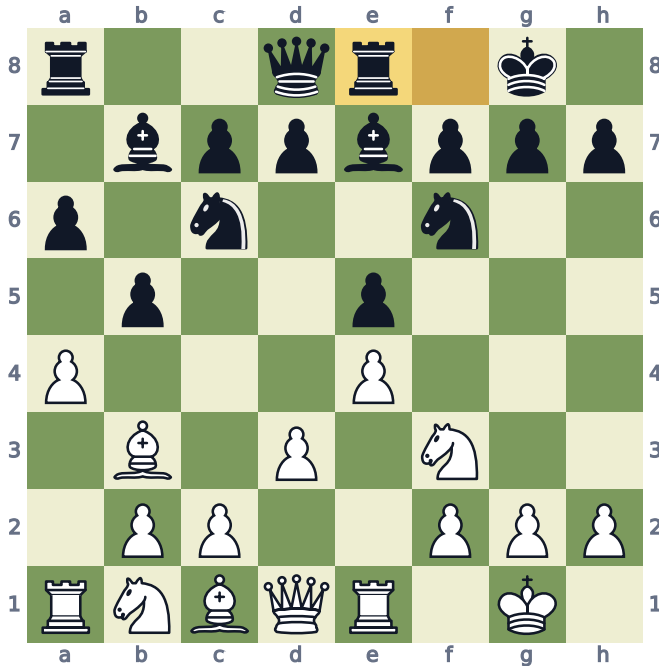
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- a4: White attacks the queenside pawn chain and tries to create a lasting target.
- Bb7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Re8: Black places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

a4 attacks the queenside chain and changes Black's ...d5 sacrifice because b5 can become loose.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Does a4 win a target now, or does it merely force Black into a different stable structure? White's resource is: White fixes a queenside target, keeps the center compact, and later chooses c3-d4. The line fails as a template when: Assuming the Marshall is avoided and relaxing about Black's central activity.

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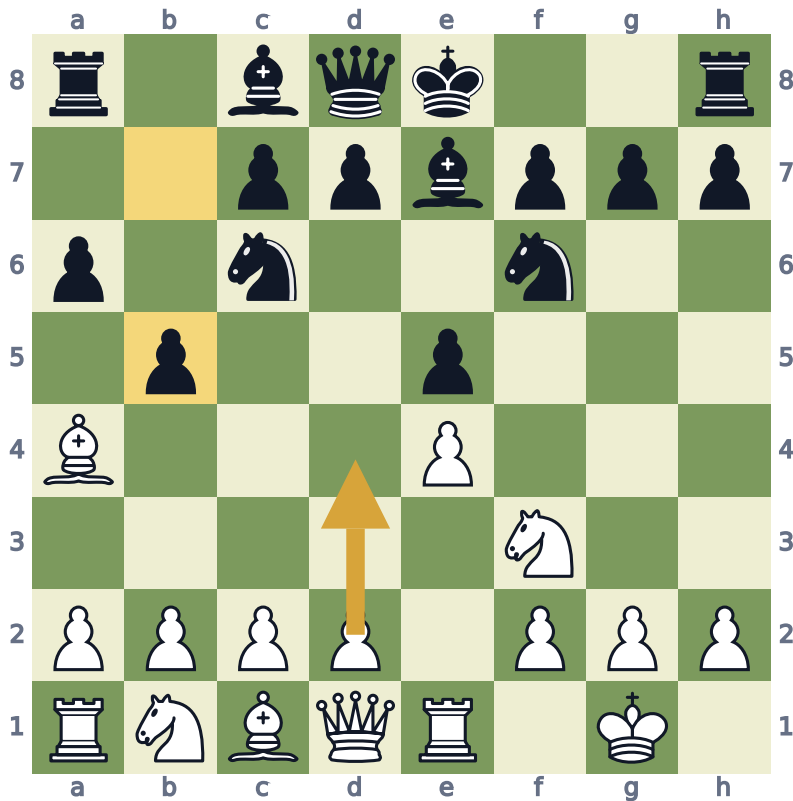
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. Bb3 O-O 8. a4 Bb7 9. d3 Re8

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Early h3 move order



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

h3 keeps options open and prevents a pin, but it does not challenge the center directly.

DECISION RULE

What option did h3 preserve, and what central freedom did it give Black?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Black develops flexibly and can choose ...d6, ...Bb7, or central play without the exact Marshall move order.

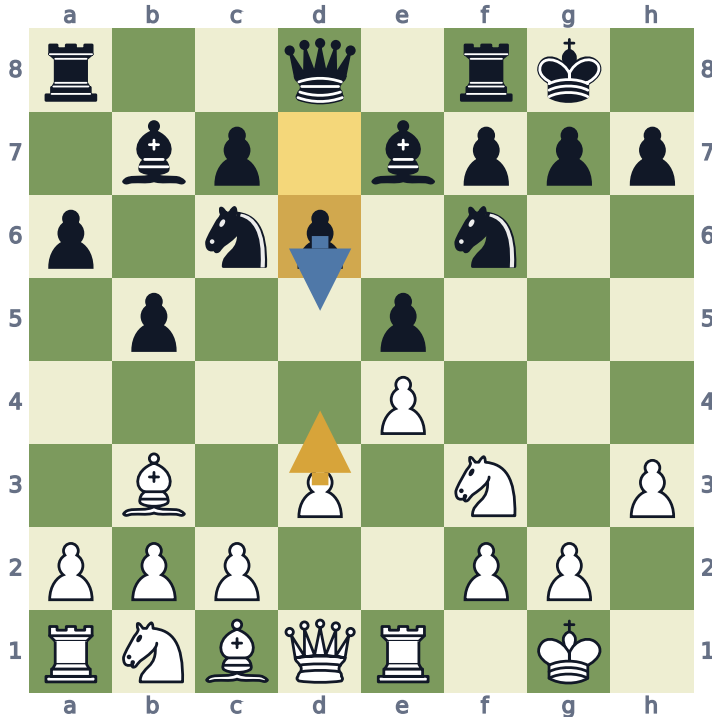
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White uses the useful waiting move to select d3 or c3-d4 after Black reveals the setup.

MEMORY RULE | A move-order tool is successful only if you know the new position it creates.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

h3 keeps options open and prevents a pin, but it does not challenge the center directly.

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White uses the useful waiting move to select d3 or c3-d4 after Black reveals the setup.

FAILURE MODE

Thinking a move-order sidestep removes the need to understand the resulting middlegame.

DECISION TEST

Ask: What option did h3 preserve, and what central freedom did it give Black? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

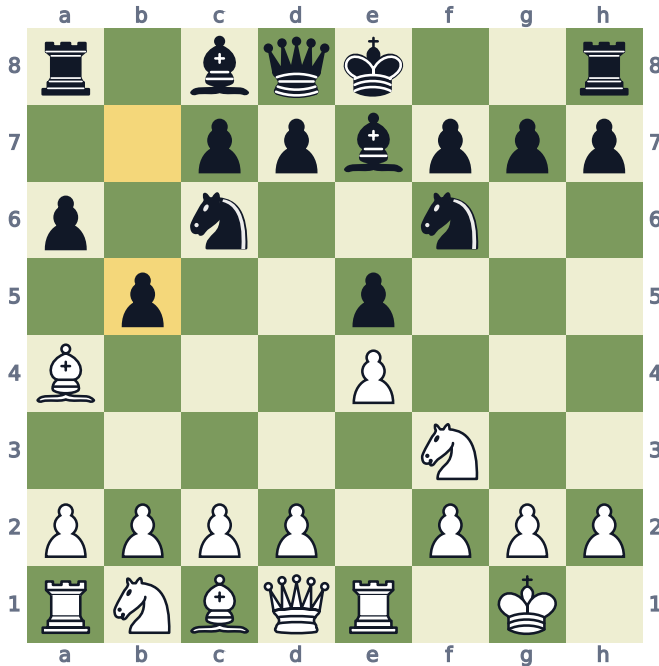
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Move-by-move meaning

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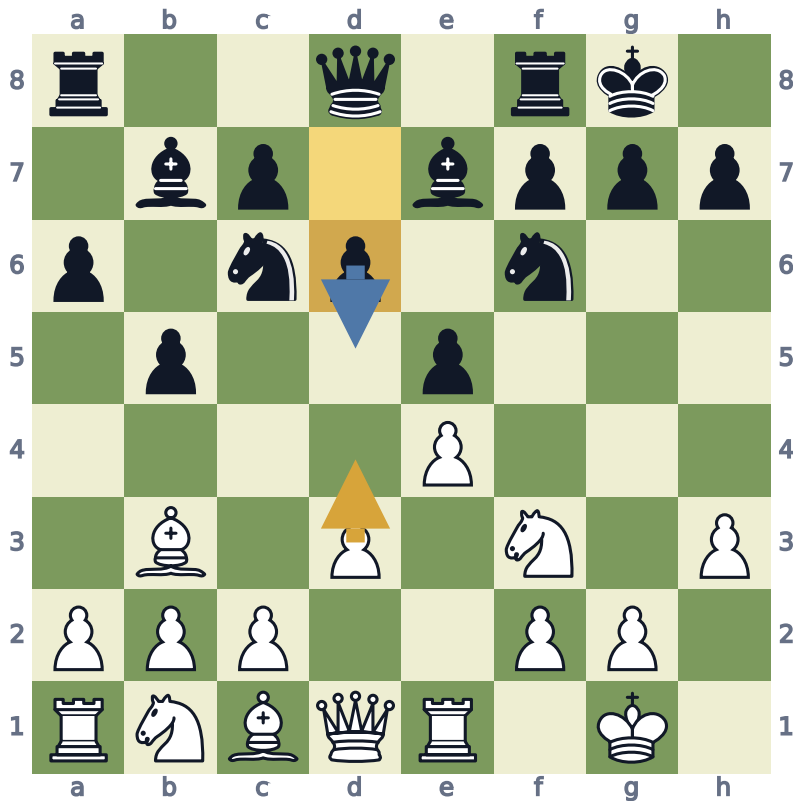
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Early h3 move order



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

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What option did h3 preserve, and what central freedom did it give Black?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

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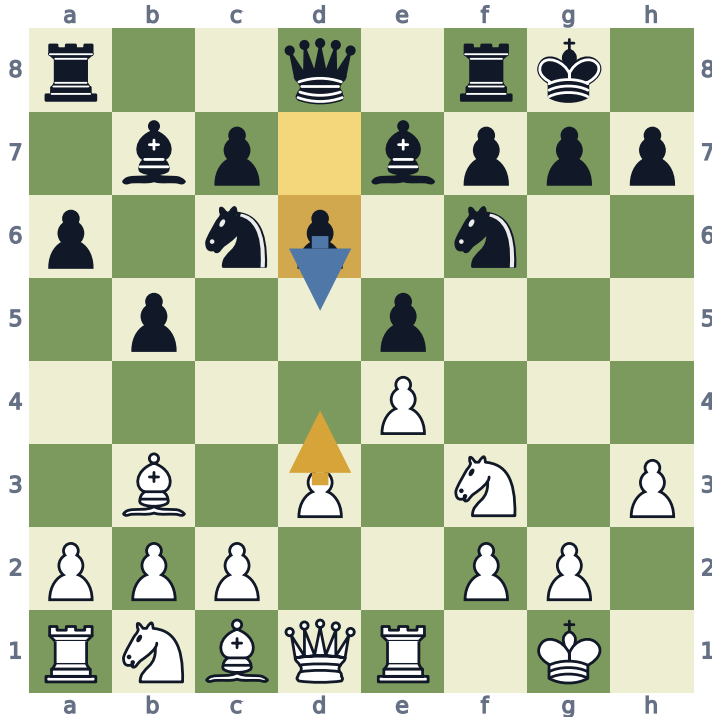
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK'S PLAN

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White uses the useful waiting move to select d3 or c3-d4 after Black reveals the setup.

FAILURE MODE

Thinking a move-order sidestep removes the need to understand the resulting middlegame.

DECISION TEST

Ask: What option did h3 preserve, and what central freedom did it give Black? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

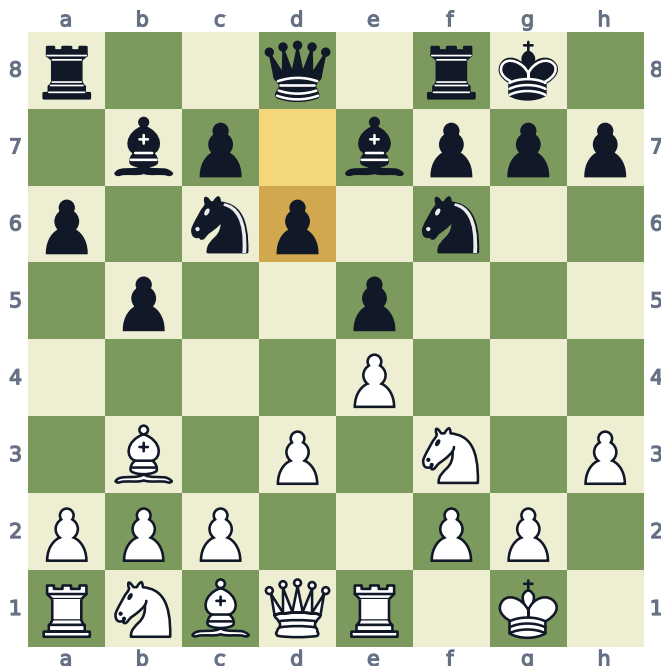
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- h3: White prevents a pin and supports the coming central plan at the cost of one tempo.
- Bb7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

h3 keeps options open and prevents a pin, but it does not challenge the center directly.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

What option did h3 preserve, and what central freedom did it give Black? White's resource is: White uses the useful waiting move to select d3 or c3-d4 after Black reveals the setup. The line fails as a template when: Thinking a move-order sidestep removes the need to understand the resulting middlegame.

STORE THIS | A move-order tool is successful only if you know the new position it creates.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

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ANSWER KEY

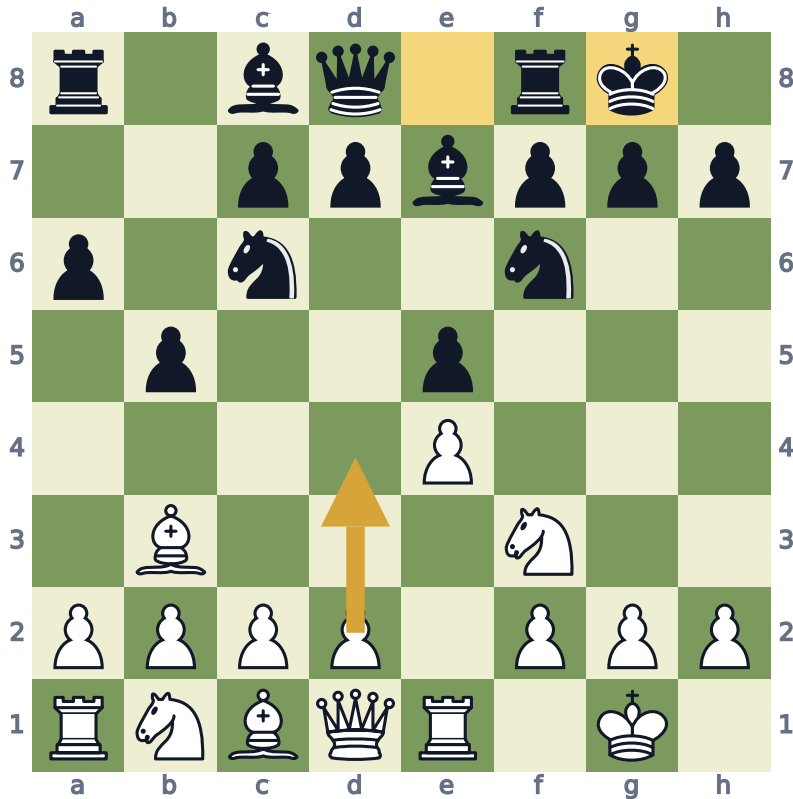
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. Bb3 O-O 8. h3 Bb7 9. d3 d6

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Anti-Marshall d3 center



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

The d3 center denies immediate central liquidation and leads to maneuvering where queenside weaknesses and piece routes matter.

DECISION RULE

Which side can improve a piece without fixing a new weakness?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Black uses ...Bf8, ...g6, or ...d5 preparation and avoids defending b5 passively.

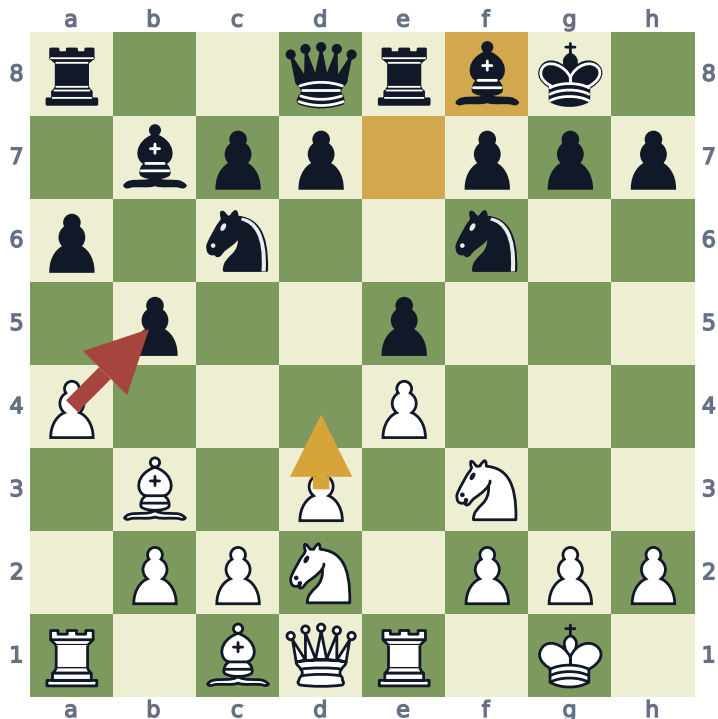
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White pressures b5, reroutes knights, and chooses d4 when the pieces are ideally placed.

MEMORY RULE | In anti-Marshall positions, the game returns to Spanish maneuvering; improve the worst piece.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

The d3 center denies immediate central liquidation and leads to maneuvering where queenside weaknesses and piece routes matter.

BLACK'S PLAN

Black uses ...Bf8, ...g6, or ...d5 preparation and avoids defending b5 passively.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White pressures b5, reroutes knights, and chooses d4 when the pieces are ideally placed.

FAILURE MODE

Obsessing over the b5 pawn while the opponent takes over the center.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which side can improve a piece without fixing a new weakness? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

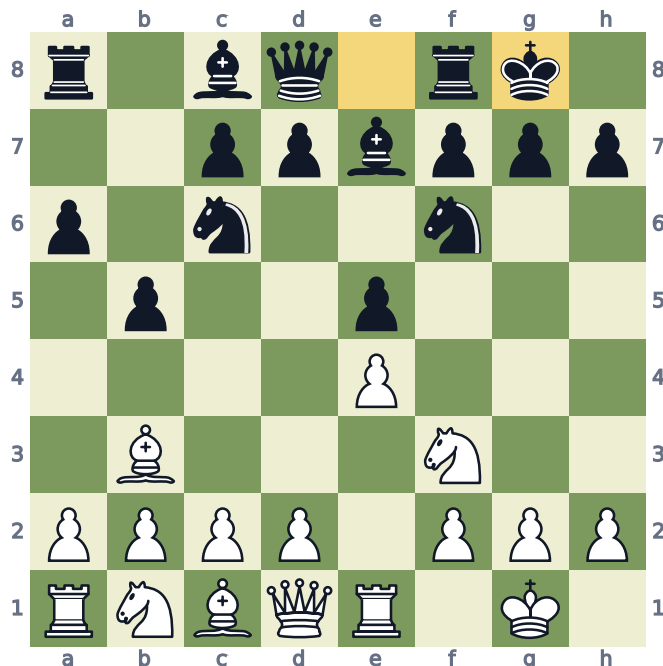
RULE | In anti-Marshall positions, the game returns to Spanish maneuvering; improve the worst piece.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. a4 Bb7 9. d3 Re8 10. Nbd2 Bf8



- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- b5: Black gains bishop tempo and queenside space while creating a possible pawn target.
- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The d3 center denies immediate central liquidation and leads to maneuvering where queenside weaknesses and piece routes matter.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which side can improve a piece without fixing a new weakness? White's resource is: White pressures b5, reroutes knights, and chooses d4 when the pieces are ideally placed. The line fails as a template when: Obsessing over the b5 pawn while the opponent takes over the center.

STORE THIS | In anti-Marshall positions, the game returns to Spanish maneuvering; improve the worst piece.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

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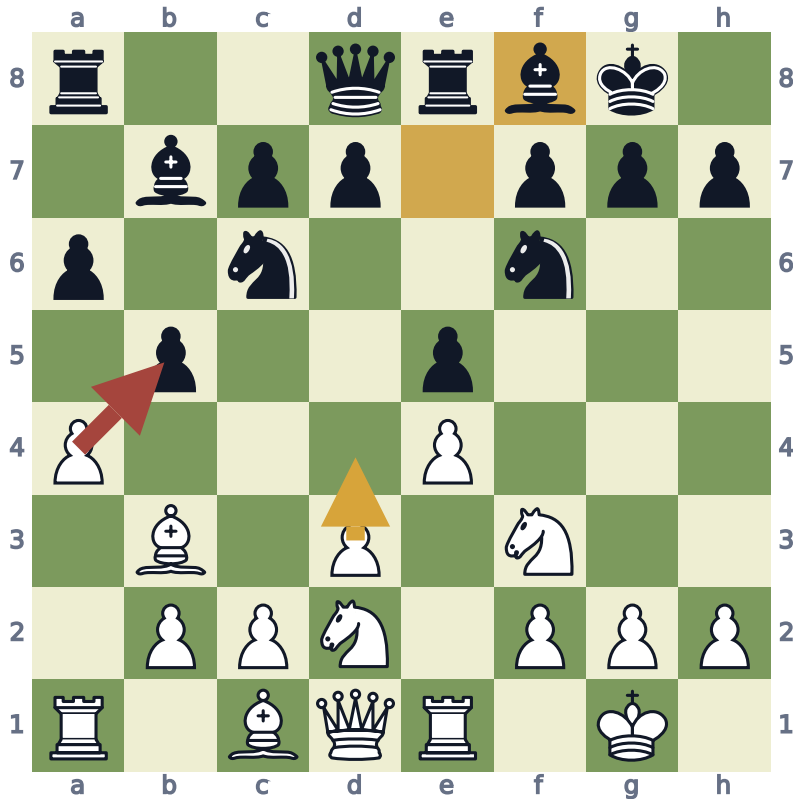
1. The d3 center denies immediate central liquidation and leads to maneuvering where queenside weaknesses and piece routes matter. 2. Black uses ...Bf8, ...g6, or ...d5 preparation and avoids defending b5 passively. 3. White pressures b5, reroutes knights, and chooses d4 when the pieces are ideally placed. 4. Which side can improve a piece without fixing a new weakness? 5. Obsessing over the b5 pawn while the opponent takes over the center.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 O-O

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Anti-Marshall d3 center



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

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DECISION RULE

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SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

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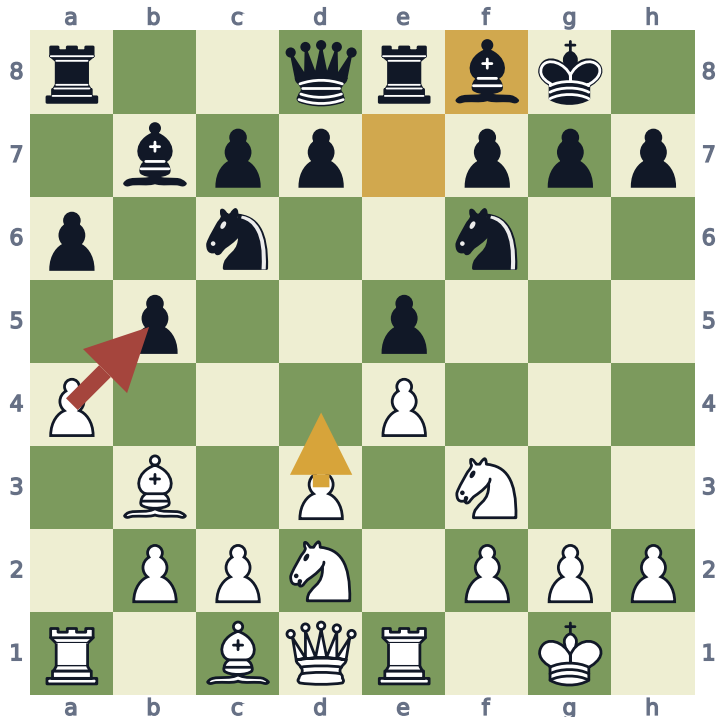
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MEMORY RULE | In anti-Marshall positions, the game returns to Spanish maneuvering; improve the worst piece.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

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FAILURE MODE

Obsessing over the b5 pawn while the opponent takes over the center.

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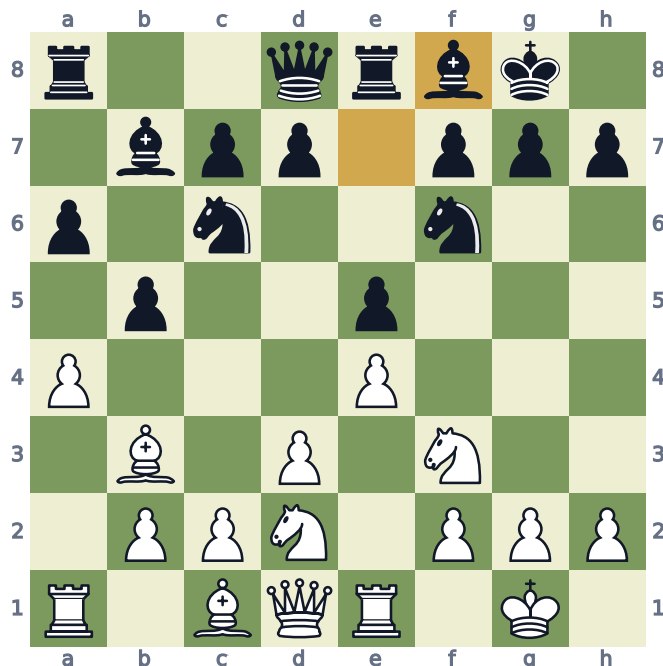
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- Bb7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d3: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Re8: Black places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- Nbd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Bf8: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

The d3 center denies immediate central liquidation and leads to maneuvering where queenside weaknesses and piece routes matter.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which side can improve a piece without fixing a new weakness? White's resource is: White pressures b5, reroutes knights, and chooses d4 when the pieces are ideally placed. The line fails as a template when: Obsessing over the b5 pawn while the opponent takes over the center.

STORE THIS | In anti-Marshall positions, the game returns to Spanish maneuvering; improve the worst piece.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. The d3 center denies immediate central liquidation and leads to maneuvering where queenside weaknesses and piece routes matter. 2. Black uses ...Bf8, ...g6, or ...d5 preparation and avoids defending b5 passively. 3. White pressures b5, reroutes knights, and chooses d4 when the pieces are ideally placed. 4. Which side can improve a piece without fixing a new weakness? 5. Obsessing over the b5 pawn while the opponent takes over the center.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 20 plies from memory, then replay: 8. a4 Bb7 9. d3 Re8 10. Nbd2 Bf8

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 043 Decode: 8.a4 restrains ...b5

Prompt: Does a4 win a target now, or does it merely force Black into a different stable structure?

Recall: Avoiding one system means accepting another; know what a4 weakens and attacks.

LESSON 044 Play: 8.a4 restrains ...b5

Prompt: Does a4 win a target now, or does it merely force Black into a different stable structure?

Recall: Avoiding one system means accepting another; know what a4 weakens and attacks.

LESSON 045 Decode: Early h3 move order

Prompt: What option did h3 preserve, and what central freedom did it give Black?

Recall: A move-order tool is successful only if you know the new position it creates.

LESSON 046 Play: Early h3 move order

Prompt: What option did h3 preserve, and what central freedom did it give Black?

Recall: A move-order tool is successful only if you know the new position it creates.

LESSON 047 Decode: Anti-Marshall d3 center

Prompt: Which side can improve a piece without fixing a new weakness?

Recall: In anti-Marshall positions, the game returns to Spanish maneuvering; improve the worst piece.

LESSON 048 Play: Anti-Marshall d3 center

Prompt: Which side can improve a piece without fixing a new weakness?

Recall: In anti-Marshall positions, the game returns to Spanish maneuvering; improve the worst piece.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's plan, one candidate for the side to move, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

8.a4 restrains ...b5

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. a4 Bb7 9. d3 Re8

Decision: Does a4 win a target now, or does it merely force Black into a different stable structure?

Memory: Avoiding one system means accepting another; know what a4 weakens and attacks.

CARD 2

Early h3 move order

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. h3 Bb7 9. d3 d6

Decision: What option did h3 preserve, and what central freedom did it give Black?

Memory: A move-order tool is successful only if you know the new position it creates.

CARD 3

Anti-Marshall d3 center

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. a4 Bb7 9. d3 Re8 10. Nbd2 Bf8

Decision: Which side can improve a piece without fixing a new weakness?

Memory: In anti-Marshall positions, the game returns to Spanish maneuvering; improve the worst piece.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
043 Decode: 8.a4 restrains ...b5	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
044 Play: 8.a4 restrains ...b5	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
045 Decode: Early h3 move order	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
046 Play: Early h3 move order	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
047 Decode: Anti-Marshall d3 center	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
048 Play: Anti-Marshall d3 center	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name both sides' strongest plans, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.